



—Associated Press

Dues-Paying Has Taken Toll on Weaver, But Just Try Convincing Umpires

Fiery Weaver Aging But Not Mellowing

By BOB RUBIN
Herald Sports Writer

A boy about four years old leaned over the rail from his seat behind third base at Miami Stadium Saturday morning. He was watching 22 Baltimore Oriole pitchers and catchers loosen up for their second day of spring training, and he was so intent he nearly tumbled over onto the field and joined them.

"See that little guy?" Oriole Manager Earl Weaver said, gesturing behind him. "That was me at the ball park with my parents back in St. Louis. My folks were big fans and would take me to Cardinal games and Browns games. [For younger fans, the St. Louis Browns moved to Baltimore in 1952 and changed their names to the Orioles.]

"The Cardinals had the Gashouse Gang then. Durocher, Frisch, Pepper Martin, the Dean brothers. I'd be hanging over the rail watching them just like that little guy. I was very young, but I do have memories."

Weaver was too young to make a lifetime career choice then. He waited until he reached grammar school before deciding that professional baseball was all he wanted to do. He hasn't changed his mind since, and that has been to the benefit of both Weaver and baseball.

WEAVER has paid his dues, and then some. A second baseman in the minor-league systems of the Cardinals and Pittsburgh Pirates, he played parts of 14 seasons for 13 teams and never made the big leagues. He managed seven teams for 12 seasons in the bushes (five as player-manager) before finally becoming a major leaguer as field boss of the Orioles in 1967.

The years of bumpy bus rides, rushing to wait for planes, irregular eating, living out of a suitcase, making decisions, battling umpires, staying up too late, smoking and drinking too much, bearing the ultimate responsibility for his teams' success or failure have combined to

take a noticeable toll.

Weaver won't be 49 until Aug. 14, but his wrinkled face, gray hair and raspy voice make him look and sound 10 years older, and he talks about retiring to life in a Miami townhouse in two or three years.

But don't write eulogies for Earl Weaver yet. He stands five feet seven inches tall and doesn't lose even a fraction of an inch to a stoop. He retains the bantam-rooster walk and the feisty, aggressive nature so often found in little men.

He is still a fiery competitor. Weaver was thrown out of seven games last season to raise his career total to 65. Try convincing the umpires he's approaching senior citizenship.

WHEN WEAVER does quit baseball, he'll leave one of the most distinguished managing records in history. To date, his teams have finished over .500 every year but his first, a stretch of 22 seasons. Seventeen of his last 21 teams finished first or second.

The Orioles finished fourth in last year's loaded American League Eastern Division, but their 90 victories were seventh most in the majors, more than the division champion Philadelphia Phils won in the NL East.

It was the ninth time in the last 11 years the Orioles have won 90 or more games under Weaver. His career winning percentage is third behind Joe McCarthy and Sparky Anderson among managers with a minimum of five major-league seasons.

The numbers show only that Weaver has succeeded at his chosen profession. They do not tell how and why. You've heard the theory that a manager's importance is overrated, that any knowledgeable fan could do it. Surprisingly, Weaver agrees.

"THE MAGIC word is knowledge," he said. "I've got 32 years of knowledge, and if he has that, then he can do the job. If he knows the intricacies of the game and what

the players can and can't do like I do after 32 years of professional ball as a player and a manager, then he can do my job."

"If he knows who can play and who can't, when to steal and when not to, who to play in left and who in center, when to take a pitcher out and when not to . . . and if he can then convince the owner and general manager that he has the knowledge and ability to make the right decisions . . . and if he then is proven right by winning enough games to keep his job . . . then he can be a manager."

Most men who reach the top of their professions are thieves. They steal ideas and methods from others along the way and assimilate them into their own beliefs.

"I learned from men I played for and men I played with," Weaver said. "I'd take a hint from this organization, a cutoff from that organization. I tried to take the best from each."

WEAVER credits George Kissel of the Cardinal organization for an appreciation of percentage baseball and a mastery of the game's fundamentals.

Weaver says he admired Eddie Stanky's perfectionism, and stole it, but not his mishandling of people or inability to communicate. Learning what to avoid is important, too. The flip side of Stanky was Andy Cohen, who managed Weaver in Denver and New Orleans more than a generation ago and taught him the value of maintaining a reasonably pleasant disposition and getting along well with his players.

Good players are the key to success in any sport. Very profound. If he had the horses, Godzilla could manage a team to the pennant. Even more profound. But a manager can enhance his players' abilities by his knowledge of their talents and weaknesses.

During the season, Weaver has stats kept for him showing how each Oriole hitter has done against every pitcher in the league.

"I walk in and see that (short-stop) Mark Belanger is a .400 hitter against Jim Kern," Weaver said. "Then I know I'm not going to pinch-hit for Belanger that night in the eighth inning if he's hitting against Kern, when most times I probably would."

"Research, being prepared, helps. But it goes just so far. There's no way of knowing when I bring Don Stanhouse in from the bullpen if he's going to get hitters out that night."

WEAVER SAYS his most important strategic responsibility over the season's course is keeping the pitching rotation steady and healthy. His toughest strategic decision is whether to lift a pitcher.

"That's one you never know."

Pitchers often disagree with his decision. For a manager, griping and second-guessing from his players comes with the territory.

"When you start, you know you're going to have a lot of unhappy players," Weaver said. "You've got 25 men and only nine can play at one time. You just have to tell people honestly how you feel."

"Sometimes there is no fair way. A guy's played good for you for four or five years, then goes into a slump. A kid gets hot, so you go with him. The older guy comes to you and says, 'Hey, I've done a job for you. Don't I deserve a chance?'"

You think, 'Sure you do — but not now.'"

Phils Seal Infield by Acquiring

PHILADELPHIA — (AP) — "That's a helluva good-looking infield, don't you think?" asked Philadelphia Phillies personnel director Paul Owens as he glanced over his new lineup.

[Mike] Schmidt at third, [Larry] Bowa at short, [Manny] Trillo at second, [Pete] Rose at first. Each one of them has been an All-Star [within] the last two years," Owens said. "Put [catcher] Bob Boone and [left fielder] Greg Luzinski out there and it's like a whole All-Star team."

Owens' remarks followed a trade that sent Phillies' second basemen Ted Sizemore, outfielder Jerry Martin, reserve catcher Barry Foote and two young pitchers to the Chicago Cubs.

In exchange, the Phils received Chicago second basemen Trillo, outfielder Greg Gross and

reserve catcher Dave Rader.

"How long have we been talking about this — six months? I can't remember ever working harder, longer on a trade than this one, but I think it's worth it," said Owens who is with his National League team in Clearwater, Fla., for spring training. "I know it's worth it, Trillo makes us a much stronger ball club."

THE TRADE was completed Friday afternoon, after 48 hours of non-stop bargaining between Owens and Cubs' general manager Bob Kennedy. The Phils had been after Trillo since last summer, and had serious discussions on acquiring him through the winter meetings.

"This trade will benefit three parties — the Phils, the Cubs and the telephone company,"

Owens said. "The money we on this deal we

The Phils lost confidence in the fracture of lost power in will be 34 in A

Trillo, 29, basemen in the eyes of P. Larry Bowa a tion.

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